UPFRONT

ECOWATCH: ORANGUTANS IN ODISHA *PG 10*

GRAPHIC: THE MISSING LINK OF KUTCH *PG 12*



REUTERS

POWER CENTRES N. Chandrasekaran and Noel Tata

▶ TATA GROUP

A HOUSE DIVIDED

Tata Sons is headed for the bourses, but a fresh twist over N. Chandrasekaran's reappointment has opened a new chapter of uncertainty at the top

By M.G. ARUN

FOR ALMOST THREE DECADES, SOME OF THE biggest listed companies in the Tata Group have held shares in a company that could not itself be traded on the stock market. That is finally coming to an end. Tata Sons, the unlisted holding company of the Rs 16.2 lakh crore Tata Group, is set to become a publicly listed company after its board cleared the proposal on September 17. The decision came after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), on September 11, rejected Tata Sons' application to surrender its status as a non-banking financial company (NBFC).

But while the listing now appears settled, the question of who will lead Tata Sons through it remains unresolved. This comes even as the board approved a third five-year term for chairman N. Chandrasekaran despite opposition from Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata, setting the stage for a fresh tussle over the leadership at a particularly sensitive juncture.

Chandrasekaran had announced on August 12 that he would not seek a third term and would step down when his present tenure ends in February 2027. He had also said that a Tata Sons board member, widely believed to be Noel, had opposed his continuation. In a statement following the board meeting, Tata Sons said, "Chandra acceded to the board's request to reconsider his decision."

Tata Trusts, however, has disputed the validity of the board's decision. In a statement, it said the resolution approving Chandrasekaran's reappointment was a "legal nullity" because